Maze (Literal, Metaphorical)

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Teen And Up Audiences

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by n7punk

Summary

Adora and Catra have finally arrived in Bright Moon after signing onto the Rebellion, but they're quickly realizing just how strange their upbringing at the hands of a hologram was and how different the halls of the Crystal Castle are from those of true royalty.
(Or, Catra and Adora's first few months as rebels)

Bring On Bright Moon

Chapter Notes

> This is part of an ongoing canon-divergent AU that is nonlinear but still won't make sense without reading at least the first fic for context. The TLDR is that Light Hope raised Catra and Adora in the Whispering Woods with them knowing Adora's destiny was to be She-ra one day.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

The queen of the Rebellion already knowing the legend of She-ra helps a lot with signing on, especially when they have to work around the dynamic of Glimmer apparently sneaking out while grounded. This also leads to them finding out what grounding is.

"What, like you're not allowed to fly? Can you fly?" Adora ask, glancing at Angella and her wings. They look like magic. Maybe Glimmer can hold them in somehow and she's not supposed to leave when she does that?

Everybody in the hallway – except Catra, at least – looks at Adora like she has grown a second head. They're supposed to be heading to a war room to debrief the Rebellion generals on everything they know about the attack on Thaymor, but Angella stopped them immediately after leaving the throne room to seemingly both reprimand and praise Glimmer.

"No, like, she got in trouble and she's not allowed to leave the house for a while now." Bow supplies. Adora frowns and glances at Catra, who just shrugs. Maybe it's a Bright Moon thing. Then again, Light Hope did something similar when they were younger, it just wasn't punishment based. She kept the inner door to the entryway closed so they couldn't use the override door to leave and endanger themselves.

"What kind of trouble? You can clearly take care of yourself," Catra asks. Adora nods in agreement. No one can handle every threat, but Glimmer is a princess. She should be fairly safe to wander Bright Moon and the Whispering Woods. They've done fine since they were little, after all.

"Not trouble as in danger, I just disobeyed an order," Glimmer clarifies, saying the last part sulkily. Adora still doesn't get it, and given the blank look on Catra's face, she doesn't either. If it's about orders, maybe this is just be how the Rebellion does discipline. That would make sense. Everybody is still looking at them like they're the weird ones, though. How were they supposed to know? It's not like they've ever been in an army before.

Adora reaches for Catra's hand and takes it, a silent assurance that neither of them is alone and they can at least be confused in this together. It has been a long time since they've been looked at like this, Thaymor's residents at least used to them being odd. Hopefully, these new friends will learn too.

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Bright Moon Castle doesn't look easily defensible from the outside, but inside its halls feel like a maze. It's good for subverting an enemy attack, maybe, but it makes trying to find anything confusing. Catra just memorizes the route from each place to the next and hopes Adora is doing the same so they can get around when they *aren't* trailing after Glimmer and Bow. The pair is clearly growing on Adora, and Catra too if she's honest – she sees the similarities between Glimmer and Bow's obvious bond and hers and Adora's – but she still feels wary of inviting new people into their lives. For now, they need their help to get around.

"We ll get you rooms to stay in tonight," Glimmer says, seemingly just chatting, as she leads them towards the dining hall. Adora perked up visibly at the word *dinner*. Catra has to admit she's excited to see what a meal in Bright Moon Castle is like. She's not sure how this works, but Glimmer said they could join them as guests, so Catra will take free food.

"Why would we need multiple rooms for sleeping?" Catra asks, scrunching her nose.

"What? No, I mean a room for each of you," Glimmer says, turning her head to send Catra a strange look.

"Why would we want that? Is this a Bright Moon thing?" Adora asks. Catra nods in her direction. A lot of the homes in Thaymor had few rooms, if any at all. She knew that wasn't necessarily standard given the other structures they've encountered, but she never thought there would be so many differences between Bright Moon and Thaymor.

Glimmer and Bow both pause, Bow looking vaguely confused and Glimmer glancing between them.

"You sleep in the same room?" Glimmer asks, like she' s verifying.

"Yes," Adora answers immediately . *Obviously*. Why wouldn't they? It' s pretty damn lonely out in the woods. All they had is each other.

"I don't know that we have any rooms with two beds," Glimmer says, so at least sharing a room doesn't seem to be *that* strange in Bright Moon. Catra's tail flicks.

"Two beds?" she asks. It' s not big deal, right? She'll just climb into Adora's if Glimmer is insistent on it. At least, if Adora wants that. Maybe she won't want to share once they have the option.

"This *has* to be a Bright Moon thing. Or maybe royal propriety," Adora decides. Catra's heart lifts, feeling at least somewhere

assured that Adora probably doesn't suddenly want separate beds. Bow looks confused, but Glimmer's expression is concentrated as her eyes wander down to their intertwined hand.

"Ohhhh, you're- I see now , but we're not prudes!" Glimmer protests. Catra exchanges a look with Adora. She' s not sure Glimmer really gets it, but whatever, clarifying will probably just make them seem weirder. Bow's gaze flicks down and his confusion breaks too. He steps forward, raising his hands as if to make a calming motion.

"It' s fine! You sharing a room will just make things easier . Those ruins were really deep in the woods. It' s too far for you to be coming and going all the time. You can keep a room here like I do," Bow offers. Glimmer brightens, quickly nodding along.

"Yeah, totally! You can crash here tonight, and then maybe after the meeting tomorrow you can go back to get some of your stuff," Glimmer adds in. Adora tilts her head.

"We don't really have 'stuff,' but we should go back just to check in," Adora agrees. Bow and Glimmer both exchange a look that seems sad.

"Your clothes, then," Bow adds, his voice gentle, like he' s trying to remind them they have *something*. Catra wrinkles her nose.

"Yeah, splitting isn't going to work for me, I have three shirts," she corrects. They're royals – well, Glimmer is at least, Bow she' s unclear on – and they probably wouldn't get it.

"I have six. I could bring three here and keep the rest at home and we'll just move yours back and forth. Then it'll be like we have the same amount of clothes," Adora proposes, giving Catra a smile that melts her heart. She purrs quietly , shifting a little closer even though their hands are already intertwined. It' s still not super practical, but the offer makes her chest feel warm.

"Why don't you guys have clothes?" Bow asks, his confusion cutting through the warm bubble that was beginning to form around Catra and Adora. Catra's purrs cuts off as she and Adora both stare at him. He *saw* where they lived. Slowly, Adora raises her free hand and starts counting off.

"No parents." One finger .

"No money ," Catra adds, and Adora puts up a second finger .

"No jobs," Adora continues.

"Bad at sewing," Catra lists of f. Adora giggles as she adds a fourth finger, undoubtedly remembering the many ugly repairs they've done with the spare needle and thread Caprellia once gave them.

"No time or idea how to work anyway ." They're at all five of Adora's fingers now. Catra tightens her grip on Adora's other hand to make it clear she should *not* let go. Instead, Catra raises her free hand to continue the count.

"But- Didn't the villagers say you had a guardian?" Bow interrupts, raising his hand to stop Catra before she can continue. Catra exchanges a glance with Adora. They have a story for this. one they told the villagers and another they prepared for the inevitable day when they had to be a little more honest.

"Yeah, we just told them that so they wouldn't like, kidnap us out of worry since we were alone from a very young age. It was just us and an old hologram that kept the training facility running and taught us how to fight. All my clothes were gifts from the village tailor and Adora's are from supplies in the ruin," Catra explains. It's the truth, but it downplays as much of the Crystal Castle's technology and purpose as possible.

They're being stared at again.

"Wait, so like, you've really been alone this entire time?" Bow clarifies, pointing at them like he expects them to part to reveal a secret mom lurking between them. Catra raises a brow at him.

"We *weren't* alone. We had each other," she corrects quickly. From the way Adora bumps her shoulder and the pair before them startles, she probably says it with too much venom. Catra looks away, wrapping her tail around her legs to soothe herself how she can since hugging herself would mean letting go of Adora's hand. "I told you that we were alone when you were breaking in to our home," Catra says instead. Adora clears her throat.

"The ruin is called the Crystal Castle. It was built to be She-ra's training ground. We were safe there and had supplies, but yeah, we were the only living people there. Everything we know we learned from the hologram," Adora explains.

Glimmer and Bow look horrified. At least it's a change of pace from being weirded out.

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Adora is pretty sure they've been adopted. Glimmer, and Bow, and then Angella and seemingly all the guards around the dinner table too, were too busy being horrified by how alone they've been to ask too many uncomfortable questions, at least. They knew it was something to hide, but the villagers always let the absentee-guardian thing slide, so it is just as much a surprise for them that people to care so much. They're still going back tomorrow night – Light Hope is probably as close to freaking out as an Alcan be – but Angella has already made it clear this is *their* room now and they're welcome to it.

"Pretty sure they're going to engineer a convoluted 'onboarding' schedule for us so we're up here a lot," Catra comments, her tone dry, as she crawls over Adora into the far side of the bed. It's the same side she normally lies on, only their bed is by the opposite wall back in the Crystal Castle, so Catra is normally on the outside. This bed is surrounded by a canopy, which makes Adora feel like they're blind to their surroundings and at a disadvantage, but since there's a giant balcony framing the bed area, it might be necessary if they want to get any sleep with all the moonlight around them.

"I'm okay with that. It will feel good to do something new, even if it's just learning. Besides, we have a lot to catch up on," Adora decides, watching Catra pick over the mattress as she tries to find a good spot to settle. Adora raises her arm, hoping Catra will come settle by her side now it's open so they can cuddle. She doesn't know how she's going to sleep in these strange new surroundings otherwise. Even the bed is weird, a giant round poof unlike anything they've ever seen. They'll probably have to experiment to find the most comfortable position in it for them.

Catra notices her arm, trilling quietly and quickly abandoning her search to flop down next to Adora. Adora grins, wrapping her arm around Catra and tucking her close. The new bed is soft enough compared to the rubbery mattress they have back at the castle that Adora doesn't even feel like she needs a pillow, and Catra seems to agree with her, curling into her side as a comforting weight. Catra yawns, quiet, high-pitched, and scratchy. It makes Adora feel almost as much affection as her trill, but the trills are pretty hard to beat. They're *adorable*.

"I just don't want them trying to baby us. I bet we're more experienced than the junior members of the Rebellion and it's not like we can't read or anything," Catra says, nuzzling against the bed and then pausing. Adora watches her raise her head, looking vaguely grumpy. Before Adora can ask what's wrong, Catra rolls away from her, rolling in the sheets and marking along the bed with her cheek. Oh. Adora barely manages to contain a giggle, or a coo,

or *something* watching Catra scent-roll the bed until she's satisfied with its state and flops back by Adora's side with a content sigh.

Catra notices the way her eyes are shining. Her ears twitch back and her cheeks dust pink as she looks away.

"So, what do you think?" Catra hastily asks. She's clearly trying to distract from how cute she is. Adora isn't sure that's possible, but she chooses to let it go. She knows what Catra is asking without any further clarification. They've wondered aloud to each other for years about what it would be like to finally join the Rebellion or what the princesses would be like when they met them.

"I'm excited. I think the battle for Thaymor went as well as it could and I like everyone we've met. Glimmer reminds me a lot of you," Adora decides. To her surprise, Catra hisses. "What? That's a good thing," Adora says, squinting at Catra in the dim light of the canopy. Catra grumbles to herself, tucking her face down into the mattress. Adora frowns, reaching up and brushing Catra's hair back out of the way so she can pet her ears. Catra continues to sulk for a few moments more, but eventually ear scratches lure her out and she immerges from the bed.

"I just don't start liking her better," Catra grumbles, not looking at Adora. The worry in Adora's chest lightens as she snorts. That's an easy promise to make. Adora can't imagine ever feeling so much emotion for someone else. What they have is special. No one else could ever surpass what they've built together over years of wandering empty halls and landscapes, bonded by scraped knees and accidental claw pricks, constantly pitting themselves against each other to build them both up until they fight like breathing and know each other like a second language.

"I could never," Adora promises. That, combined with the fingers brushing over Catra's ear again, is enough to make her relax, a quiet purr starting. A moment later, the arm she has draped over Adora begins to knead, but luckily her claws are sinking into the mattress, so Adora can just appreciate how cute it is without having to bite

down on her reaction to the pain. She never wants Catra to stop when she gets cuddly like this.

Adora squeezes Catra, dropping a kiss into her hair and immediately getting Catra's purr ramping up. She smiles to herself. No matter how different everything in Bright Moon is, she still has Catra, and they'll figure out all the weirdness together. She can take on an army just as she can take on etiquette as long as she has Catra by her side.

Chapter End Notes

AO3 is back from the war and so am I This chapter took place all in one day because I kept having ideas (this was supposed to be a one shot) but next chapter will cover months.

Put Back The Perspective

Chapter Notes

> In the Horde, comfort didn't matter and they clearly slept on thin mattresses that honestly seem worse than cots. The Crystal Castle wasn't built in such a hostile way, but it doesn't have much in the way of furniture (it's meant to be a facility, not a home) so they still grew up in a rather unyielding environment in this AU compared to Bright Moon.

Somehow Adora thought they would fit in more in Bright Moon, but in hindsight she doesn't know why. Sure, there's a lot of soldiers here, but they still grew up in polite society. Gimmer and Bow are nice, though, and Angella seems to be hopeful about She-ra's reappearance. Favor from the Queen is probably good, even if it comes at the cost of stacking more pressure on Adora's shoulders.

Adora has been shouldering it her entire life. She can take it. As strange as Bright Moon is, it's kind of magical. There are people everywhere, there's comfortable furniture, and light streams through giant windows in every exterior wall. Even in the midst of a war, the general conversation is light-hearted. The most freeing part is that people *know* here. They don't have to pretend they're not soldiers raised alone in the woods. People look at them a bit oddly when they pass them settled on an open window sill and chattering away as they watch people move in the town below, but it's already a softer look than they received upon first arriving.

There's a whole library just *inside the castle* like it's no big deal, stocked with all kinds of books, and the librarian doesn't even judge Adora when she borrows children's books! Catra teases her about being a nerd, but she clearly enjoys when Adora reads out loud and tries to help Adora when she struggles on something she comes across. Adora wouldn't feel comfortable asking anyone else and risk making them seem stupid, but Catra has always been better at

reading than her. Then again, it's her first language, and she can get tripped up similarly to Adora when it comes to the First Ones script.

"Just get a dictionary next time, dummy," Catra teases, rolling her eyes as she lets go of the book that she was turning towards herself so she could read Adora's page. She's smiling, seeming to glow like She-ra in the golden morning light pouring in from the balcony.

Adora is grateful to have had any home at all, don't get her wrong, but she suddenly decides that the Crystal Castle sucks, actually, because she has been missing early-morning Catra her entire life and she's objectively one of the most beautiful Catras. The light makes her eyes sparkle and drenches her in warm color like she was clearly always meant to be. The blue of the castle now seems sickly in comparison. Catra has been complaining about being above ground because the sun has been waking them at dawn, but it means they get to spend quiet mornings together before going into days of war meetings, or training, or "onboarding" that seems half regulation and half designed to identify and fill potential gaps in their knowledge from being alone so long.

"I forgot about those," Adora admits after an extended period of marveling at Catra. Catra's ears twitch, but her expression doesn't switch back to teasing, instead holding Adora's gaze and looking at her with what Adora imagines is a similar expression to her own. She doesn't know why. She doubts the light is unveiling another side of her that someone selfishly locked away for eighteen years.

Maybe she's actually very, very lucky they never had this before, because she doesn't know how she would have made it through their confusing teen years if Catra was looking like this all the time. Adora was feeling a lot and nothing felt like enough. It never does, with Catra, but Adora has figured out how she can touch Catra to quiet the aching in her chest, even if it doesn't go away completely. She can compartmentalize those emotions now in ways that she struggled to when they were teenagers – in ways she *has* to if she's going to succeed as She-ra. They can't have another Mara on their hands.

She didn't as a kid, but now Adora understands how strong emotions can be and how they can make magic volatile. She has felt the surge of power before when she got caught up in Catra's presence. One time she nearly hurt her because she was on such an adrenaline rush watching Catra dance around her, impressed by her skill and going too hard to see more of it as a result, that she backed Catra up to a dangerous ledge. It was the only time she has ever seen fear flash in Catra's eyes knowing she was the one who put it there, and it reinforced for her that Light Hope was right and she needs to control her emotions.

When Catra is drenched in the light in the quiet mornings, it's harder to remember. Catra sways closer to her, something caught between awe and hope in her eyes, and all Adora wants is everything she has ever dreamed. Her entire world lays beneath Catra's fingertips and in the soft rhythm of her purr, now quietly filling the air. Adora swallows, reaching up and petting Catra like she often does when she wants to touch and be closer with no clear end goal.

Catra leans into the touch, still purring and holding her gaze. Usually this helps. Today, it makes the selfish want in Adora's chest just grow stronger. She needs to move, to change something before she makes a mistake. She clears her throat, sitting up and dislodging Catra where she was half-crawled in her lap, but she still can't look away, and neither does Catra. She looks like she's waiting, her purr petering out slowly.

"C'mere," Adora manages, her tone a little gruff as she finally looks away to carefully set her book down with her place marked. She leans back, wiggling until she's laying on the fancy couch – *chaise long*, or whatever – with her arms open. Adora swears she sees disappointment in Catra's eyes for a moment, but then she smiles and moves in to drape over Adora, so she must have been wrong. Adora quickly wraps her arms around Catra, tucking her into her chest and kissing the tops of her ears.

She told herself long ago that ear kisses are fine, because if they *weren't* she thinks she would have had a breakdown at fifteen. Catra

butts her head up into the attention, purring again, so Adora lets herself just nuzzle the soft fur and pepper her with kisses until it feels a bit easier to breathe.

The yearning is still there, but it's quieter again, probably helped by the fact that she isn't looking at Catra' s face anymore.

Maybe they should go back to the Crystal Castle tonight. Catra can get a full night's rest and Adora can work on not ruining eighteen-and-a-thousand years of planning.

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They're doing jackshit – "bonding," Bow called it, giving a speech about how it's important for synergy on the battlefield like you couldn't just *train* together and get the same effect – and the most important person in the room is just Glimmer , so Catra decides it's time to stop worrying about what counts as decorum and climbs directly into Adora's lap. Adora doesn't pause, her look of concentration merely breaking for a moment as she smiles at Catra, but then she's right back to looking all serious. She wraps an arm around Catra and sets to petting her ears with the other hand as she listens. Catra purrs quietly as Adora tousles her ears.

Bow pauses in his explanation about the rules of his board game to coo. Catra immediately hisses at him, glaring him down when he continues to smile at her. Adora shooshes Catra, which only makes Catra growl, now directing her threats at both Bow and Adora.

Adora kisses her ear and the growl betrays her, melting into a purr. Catra grumbles as she tucks her face into Adora's shoulder, positioning herself for more ear kisses and looking away from that dancing light in Bow's eyes that annoys her so much. No one is supposed to comment on the stuff she and Adora do, and they're

certainly not supposed to look at Catra like *that*. She's tough and badass. That's the same look adults give little kids and they're not children anymore.

"Sorry , you guys are just really cute," Bow says, probably trying to lure Catra out of Adora's chest, but unless there's more kisses out there, she isn't moving. She doesn't growl again, though. She'll let it slide as long as it's *both* of them. Catra isn't soft. She has ten knives at all times.

"Sure, and never heard of PDA- W ait, actually, *have* you heard of PDA?" Glimmer says, starting sarcastic before her train of thought seems to catch up with her. Glimmer and Bow have started adjusting to having to explain apparently well-known concepts to them. Catra turns her head, peeking out at Glimmer.

"Y eah, it's something adults don't like," she returns. They've definitely heard it before, usually in a laughing tone. This is the first time it has been directed at them, though.

"What' s it stand for?" Glimmer asks, her tone a little smug. Catra glares at her, her tail beginning to flick with annoyance. Adora reaches up, petting through her hair to soothe her. Glimmer smirks, satisfied she got confirmation. "It' s public display of affection.' There's stuff it's rude to do in public, like, um, kissing a lot," Glimmer settles on, getting a little flustered and glancing to Bow for help. Catra doesn't know why she' s bringing that up – it was *one* ear kiss, which isn't even a real kiss or Adora wouldn't have done it – but Adora just frowns.

"Is cuddling rude?" Adora asks. Catra hisses and immediately glares at Glimmer, daring her to say yes. Glimmer seems amused by it, but she just shrugs.

"Not exactly , there's just times when it' s inappropriate, like when there's any level of formality. Handholding is usually okay, though," she tells them. Well, at least they have *that*. They've always held

hands a lot, especially when around other people. They spent at least half their time in Thaymor with their hands intertwined.

"Well, that's just confusing," Adora murmurs to herself, her expression as concentrated as it was when Bow was reading off the rules. Catra butts her head forward, earning a chuckle and another kiss on her ear. When she pulls back again, Adora is smiling. Good. She doesn't want Adora worrying too much about that stuff. Catra might actually die if she starts pulling back.

"Sorry, I know it has to be a lot to get used to. Oh! Maybe pay attention to what Spinnerella and Netossa do the next time they come for a Princess Alliance meeting. They've been married a long time, so anything more than what they do is definitely too much," Bow says. Catra's fur suddenly feels hot. It makes sense that anything married couples aren't allowed to do in public would be off the table for them, but she wishes he hadn't phrased it like that. Catra determinedly doesn't look at anybody. From the slight way Adora shifts, she suspects she might be doing the same. Bow seems to pick up on their discomfort.

"I know you aren't used to talking about your relationship, but really, it's okay! We're friends, friends talk about that kind of thing," Bow assures. Catra gets a terrible sinking in her stomach. This conversation is taking a turn towards what feels like an inevitable conclusion looming in the distance, one she really doesn't want to reach.

Adora, because she's awful and Catra hates her guts, says, "Relationship?" in a small, strained voice, like she can barely breathe enough to push the words out. Catra's ears, already twitched back, flatten against her head as Glimmer and Bow exchange a significant look, one Catra has become all too accustomed to.

"You guys are together, right? Like, dating?" Bow asks, slowly, the dawning realization obvious in his voice that they might *not* be. Catra's fur bristles and Adora chokes on nothing. *This can't be happening.*

"What? Why would we- That's not- We're just-" Catra hits Adora in the face with her tail to reset her. Adora shuts up, closing her mouth but remaining red in the face as she stares at Bow with big, pleading eyes like she's hoping he will take it back. Catra just feels fucking *ashamed*. It's almost like rejection, except she would have snapped at Bow that they weren't together herself if she hadn't been busy feeling sick.

"Okay! That's, um, fine. There's nothing wrong with it. We just assumed," Glimmer interrupts, clapping her hands together and then staring Bow down in a similar way that Catra did to her earlier. Catra wants to curl into a ball. Instead, she reluctantly unfurls and slides out of Adora's lap, landing on the couch beside her. Their sides are still touching, but it feels so cold in comparison. It was supposed to help, but it might make her feel sicker.

"There's nothing wrong with it," Catra echoes, wrapping her arms around herself and narrowing her eyes at Glimmer. Glimmer quickly nods.

"There's stuff that generally only couples do-" Glimmer's gaze flicks to Adora's lap and Catra tightens her arms, "-but it's not like that's a *rule*. I mean, Bow and I hold hands all the time! It's fine!" Glimmer hurries to assure them. It doesn't feel fine when Glimmer's tone is a little hysterical and Adora carefully isn't looking at Catra.

"You're close! That's great! Everybody hugs, anyway," Bow hops in. It doesn't feel great when Catra's stomach is turning. What if Adora pulls away from her because of this? She wishes Glimmer and Bow had kept their mouths shut.

"How about we just play the game?" Adora says, sounding like she would rather be having any conversation but this one. Glimmer and Bow quickly nod their agreement, but even as they move to assemble their pieces, the sick feeling in Catra's chest doesn't settle.

She can't lose what she has with Adora. It's already not enough. Her heart can't take less.

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Adora is pretty sure she and Catra are both trying to be less touchy after the whole misunderstanding, but sometimes Catra's tail brushes against her hand as they stand beside each other, a glance of contact that only makes Adora feel hot and want more. Holding off on cuddling she can do, especially if it's mostly just in public. She can't stop touching Catra completely. It feels like suffocating.

These are human standards, she tells herself. Neither of them is human and they don't know how to be. They only know how to be Catra and Adora. There isn't exactly a lot of information on First Ones in the Bright Moon library and Adora isn't about to ask Light Hope about this kind of thing, but she checks out a book about magicats. Despite it being a bit too advanced for her, she finds a page about how magicats are "tactile," favoring communal living and even communal sleeping. She tries to subtly leave it out for Catra to find. It's proof there's nothing too weird or wrong about what they've always done. She swears she catches Catra reading it when she walks out of the bathroom, and that night Catra cautiously crawls into her arms, so Adora calls it a success.

It's fine. They're fine. Glimmer and Bow said it was fine. After a lot of careful observation, they don't even act that different from her and Catra, minus the cuddling they've already cut back on. Catra's tail has started to sway every time they touch now, like it makes her happy for them to push that barrier aside, and that innocent joy can't be bad, right?

It feels like something so small can't matter that much when they're fighting a war, but Adora has always been afraid of becoming another Mara. Now they're finally fighting, she needs to be more concentrated than ever. She could easily send the planet into another nosedive if she messes up. She could kill everyone,

including Catra. For the good of the planet, Adora has to keep a handle on her emotions.

t' s a balance she has been trying to walk her entire life and under Bright Moon's sun she feels dangerously close to finally tipping over.

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Catra used to love finding a nice clearing in the forest and sprawling out beneath the sun's rays for an afternoon of blowing off Light Hope. Using Adora for a pillow, she could fall asleep underneath the calming warmth, often while getting pets as a bonus. Theyre busy – theyre finally *f ighting* and going on recruitment missions and getting to kick ass – but that just means they need to rest properly too, *obviously*, so Catra has discovered a new dimension of comfort when it comes to sunbeam naps.

Pulling the canopy aside lets late afternoon light spill onto their bed and Catra gets to sink into the softness of their new mattress. t would be better if Adora was here to pet her ears too, but she's off playing with magic with Glimmer. Catra was feeling that familiar bitterness well up watching it, only made worse by the drop in affection since coming to Bright Moon, so she decided now was a good time for a nap so she would be away from Adora and the way she both infuriates Catra and makes her want her in the same instant.

She's half asleep when she registers a touch to her ears. She purrs, pushing up into the touch without opening her eyes. Soft scratches at the back of her ear rouse her enough for her to slit her eyes open, finding Adora smiling down at her.

"Sorry , go back to sleep. t wasnt important," she tells her , smoothing back Catra's hair. Catra drops her head back to the pillow,

happy to sink into Adora's touch and the haze of warmth around her.

When she finally wakes up, the warmth is gone and so is Adora. Catra blinks around the room. Dark has fallen and it doesn't take long to adjust. She feels disoriented, not used to napping for so long, but after a moment she notices a note laying on the pedestal where Adora normally keeps the sword. Frowning, Catra sits up and grabs it. It's written in the First Ones script, because Adora is *rude* and wants to make Catra work her brain first thing after waking up.

I'm going to train with Light Hope for the evening. I might not come back tonight if it runs too long, but I'll be back first thing in the morning. Enjoy dinner for me.

Catra stares at the note, her heart beating as strong as the footfalls of an elemental. There isn't even an *I'll miss you* or *sleep well* on the page.

They have never spent a night apart, not really. They've always been in the same room, even if Catra went through a phase where she stole the blanket and slept under the bed with it. Catra's first memory is Adora pulling her from the smoke. She has *never slept alone*.

Coming to Bright Moon has meant a lot of change. Catra has been doing her best to not overreact to it. She took time to get used to their new friends – namely because they were also *Adora's* new friends and she's used to getting all of Adora's attention – but after some rocky starts, she has found her footing with their small group. Even if she likes them, she can only take so much. She and Adora already don't hold hands as much as they used to. She can't start sleeping apart. She *can't*.

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Adora would have to be a monster to wake Catra up when she looked so cute and sleepy. t might have been for the best. She wanted to go to the Crystal Castle alone so she could clear her head. Getting some solo She-ra training reminded her what her priorities need to be. She cant let new friends, or people finally starting to understand them for what they are, or even jµst *being aboveground* all the time distract her from her mission. She can enþy all those things in her free time, but she has to focus on her duty first.

She feels a little more settled after training with Light Hope and talking with her about their progress on gathering the Princess Alliance, even if seeing their bedroom empty when she walks in makes something drop in the pit of her stomach. t' s jµst for tonight. t will give them both some of the space that apparently people usually need. They always jµst got their "necessary" time apart in short chunks throughout the day, the longest they had ever been apart jµst the space of one afternoon.

t' s hard to fall asleep without Catra. The Crystal Castle seems eerily qiet without the gentle wind she has become accustomed to in Bright Moon, or Catra's purr, or even her *breathing*. The bed is cold when it's jµst her , too, despite how Catra has always claimed that Adora is the furnace. They've come back to the Crytal Castle on a regular basis for training or jµst to get a little room while they were adjµsting to life in Bright Moon, but today it feels foreign and lifeless.

This was the only place she knew for so long, how did it start to feel wrong so qickly?

Catra isnt here. Apparently that' s what the castle needs to feel like home. Adora tosses and turns and talks herself into circles in her head, but eventually she must fall asleep, because she wakes to a familiar rumbling.

t should be hard to breathe with Catra splayed across her chest and rumbling away, but instead her heart feels lighter than air.

t' s a problem. A Mara-sized problem. She has been managing it this entire time, so it shouldnt feel so world-ending when nothing has changed, but seeing an outside perspective on their relationship has made her question herself. She cant talk to anyone, that would mean admitting it. Trying to add space between them clearly isnt working and she doesnt want to do it anyway . Staying course might be her only option if she wants to stay sane. Catra's purr is so soothing in her arms. She doesnt want to lose it.

She doesnt think she went to bed early enough for it to be reasonable that Catra made her way here after she had fallen asleep, especially after all the tossing and turning, but clearly Catra came regardless. Adora shifts, getting a discontented noise from Catra, but after a moment she ends up with an arm thrown over Catra's back without waking her. t feels good to hold her again, a gentle purr rumbling against her chest.

She's tired and finally comfortable, but she's pretty sure it's somewhere around morning and she has gotten all the sleep that she is going to tonight. She pets Catra's back absently here and there, but mostly she just lays there and absorbs the warmth.

Eventually, Catra's purr peters out. Adora can tell she's awake without having to see her face.

"Never do that again." Catra' s voice is quiet and rough, giving little away. Adora's hand stills on her back. Yeah, Catra didnt sleep last night either, then.

"Sorry . Ididnt want to bother you," Adora returns in a quiet murmur . Catra growls and Adora winces. "I won't," she adds on quickly . After a bit of grumbling, Catra falls silent again.

"W e do things together," she reminds, like Adora has forgotten. With how things have changed in the last few weeks, maybe she thinks

she has. Adora swallows. Catra is right. She doesnt know that she could do all this without her, and she definitely doesnt want to.

She can balance this. She has to.

"Always," Adora promises, softly, raising her hand to pet over Catra's hair.

What they've always had has to be okay. It has to be enough.

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